sometimes, as something of a simplistic caricature through tenacious myths that have an enduring hold on our collective memory. The Akbar–Birbal stories, for example, are not ‘true’ in the sense that we remember them. Through the work of scholar C. M. Naim, the Akbar–Birbal stories have been understood to be a form of resistance, a sort of wilful but gentle pushback by the powerless against the inevitability of Mughal might.

But Akbar’s journey, like that of all human beings, was complicated and uneven. He had an explosive anger that he struggled to contain, not always with success. He occasionally used surprisingly robust expletives in Hindi, which his biographer Abu’l Fazl very fortuitously chose not to expunge from the records. He cried often, and openly, upon the death of beloved courtiers and family members, and even became outright maudlin when listening to poignant songs and ballads. He struggled with bouts of melancholia, which some travellers attributed to epilepsy, a disease which appeared to run in the Mughal family. Nor was he ashamed to admit to that most human of traits: errors in judgement. From initially admiring the fortitude in women who committed sati, he became deeply critical of Hindu men who demanded such a deplorable act from their wives as a show of loyalty. From being very respectful in his youth to the orthodox ulema, he became critical, and then judgemental, of their corrupt and petty ways.

Perhaps one of the most fascinating aspects of Akbar’s life and personality was his deep bond of love, affection and respect, with the multitude of women who accompanied him on his journeys. Oftentimes the influence and achievements of Mughal women is extricated from the sweep of history and the cascade of time altogether, and relegated to a separate chapter. This presents the role of women as a static, unchanging phenomenon, unaffected by other historical events. By giving Mughal women their due, and showing how important they were to Akbar throughout his life, I hope I have been able to provide an accurate portrait of their lives and the crucial roles they played in Hindustan at the time. In the early years of Mughal rule, the Timurid women led unfettered lives; they accompanied Humayun in his wanderings and rode into Hindustan on horseback. These women were thinly veiled, participated in the public life of the Padshah, and their advice was constantly sought, as it was in the time of Babur. Hamida Banu, Salima Sultan, and Gulbadan were particularly respected and accomplished women.